

SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

Moral Theories: Deontology, Consequentialism, Virtue Ethics - Solved Practice Workbook

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

Moral Theories: Deontology, Consequentialism, Virtue Ethics

TEN-SESSION CORE PATH • PRACTICE • OPTIONAL ADVANCED • REGISTER NOTES

1 Normative theories and the anatomy of moral action

2 Three-lens decision method and Indian administrative applications

3 Scope, rights and close-option traps

4 Translating moral theory into PYQ and Mains answers

5 Moral intuition versus moral reasoning

6 Doing good beyond express rules

7 Scarcity, triage and Snowden-type disclosure

8 Moral luck and good-faith administration

9 Evidence units, directive decoding and case architecture

10 Study links, routed PYQs and final synthesis

Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

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Major learning parts and meaningful subtopics are listed in document order. Page numbers are generated from the final PDF layout; PDF bookmarks mirror the same hierarchy.

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Moral Theories: Deontology, Consequentialism, Virtue Ethics - Solved Practice Workbook

Generation: learner-v2:g1 **PYQ ownership:** Questions labelled as official reproduce the locally held UPSC GS-IV papers; routed historical demands are explicitly neutral renderings rather than invented quotations.

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

MCQ 1

A district magistrate diverts a relief vehicle to her native village because she sincerely fears for childhood neighbours, although another village has greater documented need. Which distinction prevents compassion alone from settling the ethical verdict? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Motive is the background reason moving an agent, such as compassion, fear, loyalty or private gain; it helps evaluate character but does not by itself make the chosen administrative action right.
- B. Intention is the result an agent deliberately adopts, including the chosen means; a benevolent motive can coexist with an unlawful, discriminatory or otherwise defective intention.
- C. Ethical appraisal should distinguish expected consequences, reasonably foreseeable risks and actual outcomes, because the eventual result may include luck beyond the decision-maker's control.
- D. A good end does not automatically cleanse a wrongful means: act consequentialism may sometimes permit it, while deontology imposes side-constraints and virtue ethics examines what the choice reveals about character.

Answer: A

Explanation: Motive concerns the reason moving the agent is the controlling principle. Motive is the background reason moving an agent, such as compassion, fear, loyalty or private gain; it helps evaluate character but does not by itself make the chosen administrative action right. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 2

A municipal officer exposes a procurement irregularity mainly to damage a rival, but the disclosure is accurate and protects public money. Which object of moral appraisal captures the officer's rivalry without deciding the whole case? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Ethical appraisal should distinguish expected consequences, reasonably foreseeable risks and actual outcomes, because the eventual result may include luck beyond the decision-maker's control.
- B. Motive is the background reason moving an agent, such as compassion, fear, loyalty or private gain; it helps evaluate character but does not by itself make the chosen administrative action right.
- C. A good end does not automatically cleanse a wrongful means: act consequentialism may sometimes permit it, while deontology imposes side-constraints and virtue ethics examines what the choice reveals about character.
- D. Intention is the result an agent deliberately adopts, including the chosen means; a benevolent motive can coexist with an unlawful, discriminatory or otherwise defective intention.

Answer: B

Explanation: Motive concerns the reason moving the agent is the controlling principle. Motive is the background reason moving an agent, such as compassion, fear, loyalty or private gain; it helps evaluate character but does not by itself make the chosen administrative action right. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 3

A welfare officer wants to help vulnerable families but deliberately removes eligible migrant applicants from a list to reserve funds for local residents. Which concept identifies the exclusion she knowingly chose? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Motive is the background reason moving an agent, such as compassion, fear, loyalty or private gain; it helps evaluate character but does not by itself make the chosen administrative action right.
- B. Ethical appraisal should distinguish expected consequences, reasonably foreseeable risks and actual outcomes, because the eventual result may include luck beyond the decision-maker's control.
- C. Intention is the result an agent deliberately adopts, including the chosen means; a benevolent motive can coexist with an unlawful, discriminatory or otherwise defective intention.
- D. A good end does not automatically cleanse a wrongful means: act consequentialism may sometimes permit it, while deontology imposes side-constraints and virtue ethics examines what the choice reveals about character.

Answer: C

Explanation: Intention is the result deliberately chosen is the controlling principle. Intention is the result an agent deliberately adopts, including the chosen means; a benevolent motive can coexist with an unlawful, discriminatory or otherwise defective intention. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 4

A police officer wishes to prevent violence and knowingly plans an unlawful collective punishment of an entire neighbourhood. Which element remains defective even if the underlying public-safety motive is sincere? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Ethical appraisal should distinguish expected consequences, reasonably foreseeable risks and actual outcomes, because the eventual result may include luck beyond the decision-maker's control.
- B. A good end does not automatically cleanse a wrongful means: act consequentialism may sometimes permit it, while deontology imposes side-constraints and virtue ethics examines what the choice reveals about character.
- C. Motive is the background reason moving an agent, such as compassion, fear, loyalty or private gain; it helps evaluate character but does not by itself make the chosen administrative action right.
- D. Intention is the result an agent deliberately adopts, including the chosen means; a benevolent motive can coexist with an unlawful, discriminatory or otherwise defective intention.

Answer: D

Explanation: Intention is the result deliberately chosen is the controlling principle. Intention is the result an agent deliberately adopts, including the chosen means; a benevolent motive can coexist with an unlawful, discriminatory or otherwise defective intention. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 5

Two engineers approve equally well-tested flood barriers; an unforeseeable landslide destroys one while the other succeeds. Which distinction guards against treating the different outcomes as proof of different diligence? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Ethical appraisal should distinguish expected consequences, reasonably foreseeable risks and actual outcomes, because the eventual result may include luck beyond the decision-maker's control.
- B. Motive is the background reason moving an agent, such as compassion, fear, loyalty or private gain; it helps evaluate character but does not by itself make the chosen administrative action right.
- C. Intention is the result an agent deliberately adopts, including the chosen means; a benevolent motive can coexist with an unlawful, discriminatory or otherwise defective intention.
- D. A good end does not automatically cleanse a wrongful means: act consequentialism may sometimes permit it, while deontology imposes side-constraints and virtue ethics examines what the choice reveals about character.

Answer: A

Explanation: **Expected and actual consequences must be separated** is the controlling principle. Ethical appraisal should distinguish expected consequences, reasonably foreseeable risks and actual outcomes, because the eventual result may include luck beyond the decision-maker's control. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 6

A vaccination campaign produces a rare adverse event that was neither known nor reasonably predictable when approved. Which proposition requires judging the decision by expected risk as well as the realised harm? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Intention is the result an agent deliberately adopts, including the chosen means; a benevolent motive can coexist with an unlawful, discriminatory or otherwise defective intention.
- B. Ethical appraisal should distinguish expected consequences, reasonably foreseeable risks and actual outcomes, because the eventual result may include luck beyond the decision-maker's control.
- C. A good end does not automatically cleanse a wrongful means: act consequentialism may sometimes permit it, while deontology imposes side-constraints and virtue ethics examines what the choice reveals about character.
- D. Motive is the background reason moving an agent, such as compassion, fear, loyalty or private gain; it helps evaluate character but does not by itself make the chosen administrative action right.

Answer: B

Explanation: **Expected and actual consequences must be separated** is the controlling principle. Ethical appraisal should distinguish expected consequences, reasonably foreseeable risks and actual outcomes, because the eventual result may include luck beyond the decision-maker's control. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 7

A state proposes secretly intercepting every citizen's messages to locate a small terrorist cell. Which proposition explains why public safety cannot by itself settle the morality of indiscriminate surveillance? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Motive is the background reason moving an agent, such as compassion, fear, loyalty or private gain; it helps evaluate character but does not by itself make the chosen administrative action right.
- B. Intention is the result an agent deliberately adopts, including the chosen means; a benevolent motive can coexist with an unlawful, discriminatory or otherwise defective intention.
- C. A good end does not automatically cleanse a wrongful means: act consequentialism may sometimes permit it, while deontology imposes side-constraints and virtue ethics examines what the choice reveals about character.
- D. Ethical appraisal should distinguish expected consequences, reasonably foreseeable risks and actual outcomes, because the eventual result may include luck beyond the decision-maker's control.

Answer: C

Explanation: Good ends do not automatically cleanse bad means is the controlling principle. A good end does not automatically cleanse a wrongful means: act consequentialism may sometimes permit it, while deontology imposes side-constraints and virtue ethics examines what the choice reveals about character. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 8

A block officer fabricates attendance records so that deserving labourers receive delayed MGNREGA wages. Which analytical claim requires separate scrutiny of the benevolent objective and the dishonest method? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Intention is the result an agent deliberately adopts, including the chosen means; a benevolent motive can coexist with an unlawful, discriminatory or otherwise defective intention.
- B. Ethical appraisal should distinguish expected consequences, reasonably foreseeable risks and actual outcomes, because the eventual result may include luck beyond the decision-maker's control.
- C. Motive is the background reason moving an agent, such as compassion, fear, loyalty or private gain; it helps evaluate character but does not by itself make the chosen administrative action right.
- D. A good end does not automatically cleanse a wrongful means: act consequentialism may sometimes permit it, while deontology imposes side-constraints and virtue ethics examines what the choice reveals about character.

Answer: D

Explanation: Good ends do not automatically cleanse bad means is the controlling principle. A good end does not automatically cleanse a wrongful means: act consequentialism may sometimes permit it, while deontology imposes side-constraints and virtue ethics examines what the choice reveals about character. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 9

A licensing officer accepts one undisclosed gift because the application is otherwise meritorious and says no harm will follow. Which test asks what would happen to the practice if every officer adopted that maxim? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Kantian universalisation asks whether the operative maxim could be consistently adopted by everyone, not merely whether the present exception benefits the individual decision-maker.
- B. The humanity formula prohibits treating persons merely as instruments, establishing a dignity and rights floor below which aggregate welfare calculations cannot ordinarily descend.
- C. Deontological reasons are often agent-relative: an official's own duty not to falsify records remains binding even when another person might otherwise produce a worse outcome.
- D. Deontology excludes consequences as the foundation of duty, not from practical planning; hard cases require identifying genuinely conflicting duties and giving a reasoned account of priority.

Answer: A

Explanation: Universalisation tests the operative maxim is the controlling principle. Kantian universalisation asks whether the operative maxim could be consistently adopted by everyone, not merely whether the present exception benefits the individual decision-maker. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 10

A tax official proposes lying to one taxpayer to secure quick payment while expecting citizens generally to trust official notices. Which Kantian test exposes the contradiction in the proposed maxim? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Deontological reasons are often agent-relative: an official's own duty not to falsify records remains binding even when another person might otherwise produce a worse outcome.
- B. Kantian universalisation asks whether the operative maxim could be consistently adopted by everyone, not merely whether the present exception benefits the individual decision-maker.
- C. Deontology excludes consequences as the foundation of duty, not from practical planning; hard cases require identifying genuinely conflicting duties and giving a reasoned account of priority.
- D. The humanity formula prohibits treating persons merely as instruments, establishing a dignity and rights floor below which aggregate welfare calculations cannot ordinarily descend.

Answer: B

Explanation: Universalisation tests the operative maxim is the controlling principle. Kantian universalisation asks whether the operative maxim could be consistently adopted by everyone, not merely whether the present exception benefits the individual decision-maker. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 11

A district plans a hazardous medical trial on poorly informed prisoners because the results could benefit millions. Which principle rejects using them merely as instruments for aggregate benefit? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Kantian universalisation asks whether the operative maxim could be consistently adopted by everyone, not merely whether the present exception benefits the individual decision-maker.
- B. Deontological reasons are often agent-relative: an official's own duty not to falsify records remains binding even when another person might otherwise produce a worse outcome.
- C. The humanity formula prohibits treating persons merely as instruments, establishing a dignity and rights floor below which aggregate welfare calculations cannot ordinarily descend.
- D. Deontology excludes consequences as the foundation of duty, not from practical planning; hard cases require identifying genuinely conflicting duties and giving a reasoned account of priority.

Answer: C

Explanation: **Humanity must never be treated merely as a means** is the controlling principle. The humanity formula prohibits treating persons merely as instruments, establishing a dignity and rights floor below which aggregate welfare calculations cannot ordinarily descend. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 12

Officials publish identifiable medical details of welfare beneficiaries to demonstrate programme success. Which deontological principle requires informed respect for those citizens rather than using them as publicity material? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Deontological reasons are often agent-relative: an official's own duty not to falsify records remains binding even when another person might otherwise produce a worse outcome.
- B. Deontology excludes consequences as the foundation of duty, not from practical planning; hard cases require identifying genuinely conflicting duties and giving a reasoned account of priority.
- C. Kantian universalisation asks whether the operative maxim could be consistently adopted by everyone, not merely whether the present exception benefits the individual decision-maker.
- D. The humanity formula prohibits treating persons merely as instruments, establishing a dignity and rights floor below which aggregate welfare calculations cannot ordinarily descend.

Answer: D

Explanation: **Humanity must never be treated merely as a means** is the controlling principle. The humanity formula prohibits treating persons merely as instruments, establishing a dignity and rights floor below which aggregate welfare calculations cannot ordinarily descend. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 13

A superior tells an accounts officer to alter one figure, warning that refusal will lead a less scrupulous colleague to falsify the entire statement. Which principle explains why the officer still has a personal duty not to falsify? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Deontological reasons are often agent-relative: an official's own duty not to falsify records remains binding even when another person might otherwise produce a worse outcome.
- B. Kantian universalisation asks whether the operative maxim could be consistently adopted by everyone, not merely whether the present exception benefits the individual decision-maker.
- C. The humanity formula prohibits treating persons merely as instruments, establishing a dignity and rights floor below which aggregate welfare calculations cannot ordinarily descend.
- D. Deontology excludes consequences as the foundation of duty, not from practical planning; hard cases require identifying genuinely conflicting duties and giving a reasoned account of priority.

Answer: A

Explanation: **Some duties generate agent-relative restraints** is the controlling principle. Deontological reasons are often agent-relative: an official's own duty not to falsify records remains binding even when another person might otherwise produce a worse outcome. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 14

A jail superintendent is asked to torture one suspect because another agency may use harsher methods if she refuses. Which proposition rejects transferring moral responsibility to the predicted conduct of others? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. The humanity formula prohibits treating persons merely as instruments, establishing a dignity and rights floor below which aggregate welfare calculations cannot ordinarily descend.
- B. Deontological reasons are often agent-relative: an official's own duty not to falsify records remains binding even when another person might otherwise produce a worse outcome.
- C. Deontology excludes consequences as the foundation of duty, not from practical planning; hard cases require identifying genuinely conflicting duties and giving a reasoned account of priority.
- D. Kantian universalisation asks whether the operative maxim could be consistently adopted by everyone, not merely whether the present exception benefits the individual decision-maker.

Answer: B

Explanation: **Some duties generate agent-relative restraints** is the controlling principle. Deontological reasons are often agent-relative: an official's own duty not to falsify records remains binding even when another person might otherwise produce a worse outcome. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 15

During a riot, a magistrate must protect life while also respecting lawful assembly and proportional force. Which formulation allows consequences to inform implementation without making expected welfare the sole source of duty? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Kantian universalisation asks whether the operative maxim could be consistently adopted by everyone, not merely whether the present exception benefits the individual decision-maker.
- B. The humanity formula prohibits treating persons merely as instruments, establishing a dignity and rights floor below which aggregate welfare calculations cannot ordinarily descend.
- C. Deontology excludes consequences as the foundation of duty, not from practical planning; hard cases require identifying genuinely conflicting duties and giving a reasoned account of priority.
- D. Deontological reasons are often agent-relative: an official's own duty not to falsify records remains binding even when another person might otherwise produce a worse outcome.

Answer: C

Explanation: Consequences inform planning but do not create duty is the controlling principle. Deontology excludes consequences as the foundation of duty, not from practical planning; hard cases require identifying genuinely conflicting duties and giving a reasoned account of priority. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 16

A doctor in a government hospital faces duties of confidentiality and protection of an identifiable third party from serious harm. Which deontological approach requires reasoned prioritisation rather than mechanically repeating one rule? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. The humanity formula prohibits treating persons merely as instruments, establishing a dignity and rights floor below which aggregate welfare calculations cannot ordinarily descend.
- B. Deontological reasons are often agent-relative: an official's own duty not to falsify records remains binding even when another person might otherwise produce a worse outcome.
- C. Kantian universalisation asks whether the operative maxim could be consistently adopted by everyone, not merely whether the present exception benefits the individual decision-maker.
- D. Deontology excludes consequences as the foundation of duty, not from practical planning; hard cases require identifying genuinely conflicting duties and giving a reasoned account of priority.

Answer: D

Explanation: Consequences inform planning but do not create duty is the controlling principle. Deontology excludes consequences as the foundation of duty, not from practical planning; hard cases require identifying genuinely conflicting duties and giving a reasoned account of priority. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 17

A city considers closing a polluting factory. Which approach requires comparing health gains, lost livelihoods, transition support, future investment signals and environmental effects across all realistic alternatives? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Consequentialism compares feasible alternatives by their expected effects on everyone affected, including indirect harms, distribution, precedent, institutional trust and long-term consequences.
- B. Act utilitarianism evaluates the particular choice and may support an exception when that act produces greater expected net welfare than every available alternative.
- C. Rule utilitarianism evaluates the consequences of generally accepting a rule, explaining why predictable and non-arbitrary procedures may outperform locally attractive exceptions.
- D. Consequentialist calculation remains vulnerable to uncertain forecasts, unequal distribution, disputed welfare measures and manipulation of whose interests or time horizon count.

Answer: A

Explanation: Consequentialism compares complete expected effects is the controlling principle.

Consequentialism compares feasible alternatives by their expected effects on everyone affected, including indirect harms, distribution, precedent, institutional trust and long-term consequences. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 18

A collector considers waiving one documentation requirement for flood relief. Which theory demands attention not only to the immediate beneficiary but also to equal treatment, precedent and future trust? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Rule utilitarianism evaluates the consequences of generally accepting a rule, explaining why predictable and non-arbitrary procedures may outperform locally attractive exceptions.
- B. Consequentialism compares feasible alternatives by their expected effects on everyone affected, including indirect harms, distribution, precedent, institutional trust and long-term consequences.
- C. Consequentialist calculation remains vulnerable to uncertain forecasts, unequal distribution, disputed welfare measures and manipulation of whose interests or time horizon count.
- D. Act utilitarianism evaluates the particular choice and may support an exception when that act produces greater expected net welfare than every available alternative.

Answer: B

Explanation: Consequentialism compares complete expected effects is the controlling principle.

Consequentialism compares feasible alternatives by their expected effects on everyone affected, including indirect harms, distribution, precedent, institutional trust and long-term consequences. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 19

An ambulance driver breaks a minor traffic restriction at an empty junction to save a critically injured child. Which version of utilitarianism focuses directly on the expected result of this individual exception? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Consequentialism compares feasible alternatives by their expected effects on everyone affected, including indirect harms, distribution, precedent, institutional trust and long-term consequences.
- B. Rule utilitarianism evaluates the consequences of generally accepting a rule, explaining why predictable and non-arbitrary procedures may outperform locally attractive exceptions.
- C. Act utilitarianism evaluates the particular choice and may support an exception when that act produces greater expected net welfare than every available alternative.
- D. Consequentialist calculation remains vulnerable to uncertain forecasts, unequal distribution, disputed welfare measures and manipulation of whose interests or time horizon count.

Answer: C

Explanation: Act utilitarianism evaluates the particular act is the controlling principle. Act utilitarianism evaluates the particular choice and may support an exception when that act produces greater expected net welfare than every available alternative. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 20

A disaster officer opens a locked public building without prior permission to shelter families during a cloudburst. Which approach asks whether this particular act maximises welfare compared with waiting? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Rule utilitarianism evaluates the consequences of generally accepting a rule, explaining why predictable and non-arbitrary procedures may outperform locally attractive exceptions.
- B. Consequentialist calculation remains vulnerable to uncertain forecasts, unequal distribution, disputed welfare measures and manipulation of whose interests or time horizon count.
- C. Consequentialism compares feasible alternatives by their expected effects on everyone affected, including indirect harms, distribution, precedent, institutional trust and long-term consequences.
- D. Act utilitarianism evaluates the particular choice and may support an exception when that act produces greater expected net welfare than every available alternative.

Answer: D

Explanation: Act utilitarianism evaluates the particular act is the controlling principle. Act utilitarianism evaluates the particular choice and may support an exception when that act produces greater expected net welfare than every available alternative. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 21

A ration officer could favour one sympathetic family today, but widespread case-by-case favouritism would undermine queues and trust. Which theory evaluates the welfare effects of the general rule? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Rule utilitarianism evaluates the consequences of generally accepting a rule, explaining why predictable and non-arbitrary procedures may outperform locally attractive exceptions.
- B. Consequentialism compares feasible alternatives by their expected effects on everyone affected, including indirect harms, distribution, precedent, institutional trust and long-term consequences.
- C. Act utilitarianism evaluates the particular choice and may support an exception when that act produces greater expected net welfare than every available alternative.
- D. Consequentialist calculation remains vulnerable to uncertain forecasts, unequal distribution, disputed welfare measures and manipulation of whose interests or time horizon count.

Answer: A

Explanation: Rule utilitarianism evaluates general acceptance is the controlling principle. Rule utilitarianism evaluates the consequences of generally accepting a rule, explaining why predictable and non-arbitrary procedures may outperform locally attractive exceptions. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 22

A procurement committee retains transparent bidding even though direct selection might be faster in one non-emergency purchase. Which approach emphasises the long-run gains of generally following a fair procedure? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Act utilitarianism evaluates the particular choice and may support an exception when that act produces greater expected net welfare than every available alternative.
- B. Rule utilitarianism evaluates the consequences of generally accepting a rule, explaining why predictable and non-arbitrary procedures may outperform locally attractive exceptions.
- C. Consequentialist calculation remains vulnerable to uncertain forecasts, unequal distribution, disputed welfare measures and manipulation of whose interests or time horizon count.
- D. Consequentialism compares feasible alternatives by their expected effects on everyone affected, including indirect harms, distribution, precedent, institutional trust and long-term consequences.

Answer: B

Explanation: Rule utilitarianism evaluates general acceptance is the controlling principle. Rule utilitarianism evaluates the consequences of generally accepting a rule, explaining why predictable and non-arbitrary procedures may outperform locally attractive exceptions. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 23

A dam appraisal counts electricity revenue but omits displacement, downstream ecology and tribal cultural loss. Which limitation exposes how selective framing can manufacture an apparently favourable net benefit? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Consequentialism compares feasible alternatives by their expected effects on everyone affected, including indirect harms, distribution, precedent, institutional trust and long-term consequences.
- B. Act utilitarianism evaluates the particular choice and may support an exception when that act produces greater expected net welfare than every available alternative.
- C. Consequentialist calculation remains vulnerable to uncertain forecasts, unequal distribution, disputed welfare measures and manipulation of whose interests or time horizon count.
- D. Rule utilitarianism evaluates the consequences of generally accepting a rule, explaining why predictable and non-arbitrary procedures may outperform locally attractive exceptions.

Answer: C

Explanation: Utility calculation contains framing and measurement risks is the controlling principle. Consequentialist calculation remains vulnerable to uncertain forecasts, unequal distribution, disputed welfare measures and manipulation of whose interests or time horizon count. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 24

An urban flyover saves commuters five minutes but imposes concentrated pollution on a low-income settlement. Which caution challenges aggregation that hides who receives benefits and who bears costs? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Act utilitarianism evaluates the particular choice and may support an exception when that act produces greater expected net welfare than every available alternative.
- B. Rule utilitarianism evaluates the consequences of generally accepting a rule, explaining why predictable and non-arbitrary procedures may outperform locally attractive exceptions.
- C. Consequentialism compares feasible alternatives by their expected effects on everyone affected, including indirect harms, distribution, precedent, institutional trust and long-term consequences.
- D. Consequentialist calculation remains vulnerable to uncertain forecasts, unequal distribution, disputed welfare measures and manipulation of whose interests or time horizon count.

Answer: D

Explanation: Utility calculation contains framing and measurement risks is the controlling principle. Consequentialist calculation remains vulnerable to uncertain forecasts, unequal distribution, disputed welfare measures and manipulation of whose interests or time horizon count. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 25

An officer repeatedly behaves honestly even when audits are unlikely and no reward is available. Which ethical approach treats this reliable disposition, rather than isolated compliance, as central? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Virtue ethics evaluates the character and stable dispositions expressed through action, not only compliance with rules or production of desirable outcomes.
- B. Aristotle's mean is context-relative practical appropriateness between excess and deficiency, not an arithmetic midpoint or a command always to choose moderation.
- C. Phronesis integrates ethical purpose, experience, perceptive attention and deliberation to identify which virtue and response are appropriate in a particular situation.
- D. Public responsibility and entrusted power shape the virtues demanded by a role; care ethics is a neighbouring relational tradition, not simply an Aristotelian subtype.

Answer: A

Explanation: **Virtue ethics evaluates stable character** is the controlling principle. Virtue ethics evaluates the character and stable dispositions expressed through action, not only compliance with rules or production of desirable outcomes. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 26

A police leader builds habits of restraint, courage and truthfulness throughout the force instead of relying only on manuals. Which theory most directly explains this character-forming strategy? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Phronesis integrates ethical purpose, experience, perceptive attention and deliberation to identify which virtue and response are appropriate in a particular situation.
- B. Virtue ethics evaluates the character and stable dispositions expressed through action, not only compliance with rules or production of desirable outcomes.
- C. Public responsibility and entrusted power shape the virtues demanded by a role; care ethics is a neighbouring relational tradition, not simply an Aristotelian subtype.
- D. Aristotle's mean is context-relative practical appropriateness between excess and deficiency, not an arithmetic midpoint or a command always to choose moderation.

Answer: B

Explanation: **Virtue ethics evaluates stable character** is the controlling principle. Virtue ethics evaluates the character and stable dispositions expressed through action, not only compliance with rules or production of desirable outcomes. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 27

A district magistrate facing communal violence rejects both reckless force and cowardly inaction, selecting firm proportionate measures. Which Aristotelian idea describes the appropriate response without averaging the two extremes? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Virtue ethics evaluates the character and stable dispositions expressed through action, not only compliance with rules or production of desirable outcomes.
- B. Phronesis integrates ethical purpose, experience, perceptive attention and deliberation to identify which virtue and response are appropriate in a particular situation.
- C. Aristotle's mean is context-relative practical appropriateness between excess and deficiency, not an arithmetic midpoint or a command always to choose moderation.
- D. Public responsibility and entrusted power shape the virtues demanded by a role; care ethics is a neighbouring relational tradition, not simply an Aristotelian subtype.

Answer: C

Explanation: The golden mean is context-relative appropriateness is the controlling principle. Aristotle's mean is context-relative practical appropriateness between excess and deficiency, not an arithmetic midpoint or a command always to choose moderation. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 28

An officer is told to split the difference between complete secrecy and full publication in every information dispute. Which proposition explains why ethical balance cannot be reduced to a numerical midpoint? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Phronesis integrates ethical purpose, experience, perceptive attention and deliberation to identify which virtue and response are appropriate in a particular situation.
- B. Public responsibility and entrusted power shape the virtues demanded by a role; care ethics is a neighbouring relational tradition, not simply an Aristotelian subtype.
- C. Virtue ethics evaluates the character and stable dispositions expressed through action, not only compliance with rules or production of desirable outcomes.
- D. Aristotle's mean is context-relative practical appropriateness between excess and deficiency, not an arithmetic midpoint or a command always to choose moderation.

Answer: D

Explanation: The golden mean is context-relative appropriateness is the controlling principle. Aristotle's mean is context-relative practical appropriateness between excess and deficiency, not an arithmetic midpoint or a command always to choose moderation. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 29

A revenue officer recognises that literal insistence on one certificate would defeat a pension rule's protective purpose, then records a lawful alternative verification. Which virtue-guided capacity is being exercised? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Phronesis integrates ethical purpose, experience, perceptive attention and deliberation to identify which virtue and response are appropriate in a particular situation.
- B. Virtue ethics evaluates the character and stable dispositions expressed through action, not only compliance with rules or production of desirable outcomes.
- C. Aristotle's mean is context-relative practical appropriateness between excess and deficiency, not an arithmetic midpoint or a command always to choose moderation.
- D. Public responsibility and entrusted power shape the virtues demanded by a role; care ethics is a neighbouring relational tradition, not simply an Aristotelian subtype.

Answer: A

Explanation: Phronesis integrates purpose, perception and deliberation is the controlling principle. Phronesis integrates ethical purpose, experience, perceptive attention and deliberation to identify which virtue and response are appropriate in a particular situation. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 30

A new collector knows every disaster manual but cannot recognise when frightened citizens need reassurance rather than another order. Which missing Aristotelian capacity links general knowledge to perceptive action? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Aristotle's mean is context-relative practical appropriateness between excess and deficiency, not an arithmetic midpoint or a command always to choose moderation.
- B. Phronesis integrates ethical purpose, experience, perceptive attention and deliberation to identify which virtue and response are appropriate in a particular situation.
- C. Public responsibility and entrusted power shape the virtues demanded by a role; care ethics is a neighbouring relational tradition, not simply an Aristotelian subtype.
- D. Virtue ethics evaluates the character and stable dispositions expressed through action, not only compliance with rules or production of desirable outcomes.

Answer: B

Explanation: Phronesis integrates purpose, perception and deliberation is the controlling principle. Phronesis integrates ethical purpose, experience, perceptive attention and deliberation to identify which virtue and response are appropriate in a particular situation. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 31

A judge must display impartiality and restraint where a private citizen may properly show personal loyalty. Which proposition explains why entrusted public roles alter the virtues ethically salient in action? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Virtue ethics evaluates the character and stable dispositions expressed through action, not only compliance with rules or production of desirable outcomes.
- B. Aristotle's mean is context-relative practical appropriateness between excess and deficiency, not an arithmetic midpoint or a command always to choose moderation.
- C. Public responsibility and entrusted power shape the virtues demanded by a role; care ethics is a neighbouring relational tradition, not simply an Aristotelian subtype.
- D. Phronesis integrates ethical purpose, experience, perceptive attention and deliberation to identify which virtue and response are appropriate in a particular situation.

Answer: C

Explanation: Public roles shape the virtues demanded is the controlling principle. Public responsibility and entrusted power shape the virtues demanded by a role; care ethics is a neighbouring relational tradition, not simply an Aristotelian subtype. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 32

A training note classifies every relationship-centred argument as Aristotelian virtue ethics. Which caution requires treating care ethics as adjacent but conceptually distinct? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Aristotle's mean is context-relative practical appropriateness between excess and deficiency, not an arithmetic midpoint or a command always to choose moderation.
- B. Phronesis integrates ethical purpose, experience, perceptive attention and deliberation to identify which virtue and response are appropriate in a particular situation.
- C. Virtue ethics evaluates the character and stable dispositions expressed through action, not only compliance with rules or production of desirable outcomes.
- D. Public responsibility and entrusted power shape the virtues demanded by a role; care ethics is a neighbouring relational tradition, not simply an Aristotelian subtype.

Answer: D

Explanation: Public roles shape the virtues demanded is the controlling principle. Public responsibility and entrusted power shape the virtues demanded by a role; care ethics is a neighbouring relational tradition, not simply an Aristotelian subtype. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 33

A procurement officer feels that an apparently compliant bid is improper before she can identify why. Which concept describes this useful but not yet defensible ethical signal? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Moral intuition is a rapid, affective judgment that can provide an early warning but may also reproduce prejudice, familiarity bias or in-group loyalty.
- B. Moral reasoning makes a decision publicly defensible by testing facts and intuitions against duties, consequences, virtues, law and constitutional values.
- C. Context-sensitive justice retains stable values while adapting their application to changed facts, knowledge and burdens; it must not be confused with unrestricted ethical relativism.
- D. Doing good beyond express rules requires lawful authority, no express or implied prohibition, equal treatment, recorded reasons and fidelity to substance without arbitrary disregard of form.

Answer: A

Explanation: **Moral intuition is a rapid ethical signal** is the controlling principle. Moral intuition is a rapid, affective judgment that can provide an early warning but may also reproduce prejudice, familiarity bias or in-group loyalty. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 34

A village official instinctively trusts applicants from his own community more than outsiders. Which feature explains why a strongly felt moral response still requires scrutiny? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Context-sensitive justice retains stable values while adapting their application to changed facts, knowledge and burdens; it must not be confused with unrestricted ethical relativism.
- B. Moral intuition is a rapid, affective judgment that can provide an early warning but may also reproduce prejudice, familiarity bias or in-group loyalty.
- C. Doing good beyond express rules requires lawful authority, no express or implied prohibition, equal treatment, recorded reasons and fidelity to substance without arbitrary disregard of form.
- D. Moral reasoning makes a decision publicly defensible by testing facts and intuitions against duties, consequences, virtues, law and constitutional values.

Answer: B

Explanation: **Moral intuition is a rapid ethical signal** is the controlling principle. Moral intuition is a rapid, affective judgment that can provide an early warning but may also reproduce prejudice, familiarity bias or in-group loyalty. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 35

After feeling uneasy about a tender, an officer checks beneficial ownership, conflict rules, expected public loss and fairness before acting. Which process turns an intuition into an appeal-resistant decision? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Moral intuition is a rapid, affective judgment that can provide an early warning but may also reproduce prejudice, familiarity bias or in-group loyalty.
- B. Context-sensitive justice retains stable values while adapting their application to changed facts, knowledge and burdens; it must not be confused with unrestricted ethical relativism.
- C. Moral reasoning makes a decision publicly defensible by testing facts and intuitions against duties, consequences, virtues, law and constitutional values.
- D. Doing good beyond express rules requires lawful authority, no express or implied prohibition, equal treatment, recorded reasons and fidelity to substance without arbitrary disregard of form.

Answer: C

Explanation: Moral reasoning supplies publicly defensible tests is the controlling principle. Moral reasoning makes a decision publicly defensible by testing facts and intuitions against duties, consequences, virtues, law and constitutional values. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 36

A disciplinary authority says only that dismissal 'felt right' and records no criteria. Which missing process would provide reasons capable of scrutiny by a court or reviewing authority? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Context-sensitive justice retains stable values while adapting their application to changed facts, knowledge and burdens; it must not be confused with unrestricted ethical relativism.
- B. Doing good beyond express rules requires lawful authority, no express or implied prohibition, equal treatment, recorded reasons and fidelity to substance without arbitrary disregard of form.
- C. Moral intuition is a rapid, affective judgment that can provide an early warning but may also reproduce prejudice, familiarity bias or in-group loyalty.
- D. Moral reasoning makes a decision publicly defensible by testing facts and intuitions against duties, consequences, virtues, law and constitutional values.

Answer: D

Explanation: Moral reasoning supplies publicly defensible tests is the controlling principle. Moral reasoning makes a decision publicly defensible by testing facts and intuitions against duties, consequences, virtues, law and constitutional values. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 37

Emergency movement restrictions justified during a lethal outbreak continue after the danger passes. Which principle explains how the same liberty value can require a different rule application when facts change? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Context-sensitive justice retains stable values while adapting their application to changed facts, knowledge and burdens; it must not be confused with unrestricted ethical relativism.
- B. Moral intuition is a rapid, affective judgment that can provide an early warning but may also reproduce prejudice, familiarity bias or in-group loyalty.
- C. Moral reasoning makes a decision publicly defensible by testing facts and intuitions against duties, consequences, virtues, law and constitutional values.
- D. Doing good beyond express rules requires lawful authority, no express or implied prohibition, equal treatment, recorded reasons and fidelity to substance without arbitrary disregard of form.

Answer: A

Explanation: **Context-sensitive justice retains stable values** is the controlling principle. Context-sensitive justice retains stable values while adapting their application to changed facts, knowledge and burdens; it must not be confused with unrestricted ethical relativism. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 38

A benefits algorithm once regarded as neutral is shown to exclude persons with disabilities. Which proposition requires revisiting the earlier practice without claiming that justice has no stable content? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Moral reasoning makes a decision publicly defensible by testing facts and intuitions against duties, consequences, virtues, law and constitutional values.
- B. Context-sensitive justice retains stable values while adapting their application to changed facts, knowledge and burdens; it must not be confused with unrestricted ethical relativism.
- C. Doing good beyond express rules requires lawful authority, no express or implied prohibition, equal treatment, recorded reasons and fidelity to substance without arbitrary disregard of form.
- D. Moral intuition is a rapid, affective judgment that can provide an early warning but may also reproduce prejudice, familiarity bias or in-group loyalty.

Answer: B

Explanation: **Context-sensitive justice retains stable values** is the controlling principle. Context-sensitive justice retains stable values while adapting their application to changed facts, knowledge and burdens; it must not be confused with unrestricted ethical relativism. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 39

A revenue officer accepts an alternative identity document from an elderly flood victim and records why the statute permits equivalent proof. Which principle distinguishes calibrated initiative from unauthorised benevolence? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Moral intuition is a rapid, affective judgment that can provide an early warning but may also reproduce prejudice, familiarity bias or in-group loyalty.
- B. Moral reasoning makes a decision publicly defensible by testing facts and intuitions against duties, consequences, virtues, law and constitutional values.
- C. Doing good beyond express rules requires lawful authority, no express or implied prohibition, equal treatment, recorded reasons and fidelity to substance without arbitrary disregard of form.
- D. Context-sensitive justice retains stable values while adapting their application to changed facts, knowledge and burdens; it must not be confused with unrestricted ethical relativism.

Answer: C

Explanation: **Good initiative requires authority and equal treatment** is the controlling principle. Doing good beyond express rules requires lawful authority, no express or implied prohibition, equal treatment, recorded reasons and fidelity to substance without arbitrary disregard of form. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 40

A collector waives a requirement only for a politically connected applicant, arguing that no rule expressly forbids the waiver. Which proposition identifies the missing equality and reasons safeguards? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Moral reasoning makes a decision publicly defensible by testing facts and intuitions against duties, consequences, virtues, law and constitutional values.
- B. Context-sensitive justice retains stable values while adapting their application to changed facts, knowledge and burdens; it must not be confused with unrestricted ethical relativism.
- C. Moral intuition is a rapid, affective judgment that can provide an early warning but may also reproduce prejudice, familiarity bias or in-group loyalty.
- D. Doing good beyond express rules requires lawful authority, no express or implied prohibition, equal treatment, recorded reasons and fidelity to substance without arbitrary disregard of form.

Answer: D

Explanation: **Good initiative requires authority and equal treatment** is the controlling principle. Doing good beyond express rules requires lawful authority, no express or implied prohibition, equal treatment, recorded reasons and fidelity to substance without arbitrary disregard of form. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 41

A government hospital has fewer ICU beds than eligible patients. Which framework supports clinical evidence while rejecting VIP preference and requiring transparent reviewable allocation criteria? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Ethical triage should combine evidence-based welfare maximisation with equal worth, non-discrimination, vulnerability safeguards, published criteria and periodic review.
- B. Snowden-type disclosure presents competing duties of confidentiality and democratic accountability; motive alone cannot replace necessity, minimisation, proportionality and prior-channel tests.
- C. Nagel's taxonomy distinguishes resultant, circumstantial, constitutive and causal luck; Williams's treatment should not be presented as an identical four-part taxonomy.
- D. A moral-luck correction makes ex-ante diligence primary without making outcomes irrelevant: outcomes remain evidence and feedback, while negligence, bad faith and foreseeable omissions remain blameworthy.

Answer: A

Explanation: **Ethical triage requires a constrained hybrid** is the controlling principle. Ethical triage should combine evidence-based welfare maximisation with equal worth, non-discrimination, vulnerability safeguards, published criteria and periodic review. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 42

After a cyclone, relief teams can immediately reach only three of six islands. Which proposition combines aggregate rescue impact with equal dignity, vulnerability and a public priority rule? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Nagel's taxonomy distinguishes resultant, circumstantial, constitutive and causal luck; Williams's treatment should not be presented as an identical four-part taxonomy.
- B. Ethical triage should combine evidence-based welfare maximisation with equal worth, non-discrimination, vulnerability safeguards, published criteria and periodic review.
- C. A moral-luck correction makes ex-ante diligence primary without making outcomes irrelevant: outcomes remain evidence and feedback, while negligence, bad faith and foreseeable omissions remain blameworthy.
- D. Snowden-type disclosure presents competing duties of confidentiality and democratic accountability; motive alone cannot replace necessity, minimisation, proportionality and prior-channel tests.

Answer: B

Explanation: **Ethical triage requires a constrained hybrid** is the controlling principle. Ethical triage should combine evidence-based welfare maximisation with equal worth, non-discrimination, vulnerability safeguards, published criteria and periodic review. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 43

An intelligence analyst discovers unlawful mass surveillance and considers uploading an entire classified archive without first using protected oversight channels. Which principle requires a narrower, channel-sensitive ethical assessment? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Ethical triage should combine evidence-based welfare maximisation with equal worth, non-discrimination, vulnerability safeguards, published criteria and periodic review.
- B. Nagel's taxonomy distinguishes resultant, circumstantial, constitutive and causal luck; Williams's treatment should not be presented as an identical four-part taxonomy.
- C. Snowden-type disclosure presents competing duties of confidentiality and democratic accountability; motive alone cannot replace necessity, minimisation, proportionality and prior-channel tests.
- D. A moral-luck correction makes ex-ante diligence primary without making outcomes irrelevant: outcomes remain evidence and feedback, while negligence, bad faith and foreseeable omissions remain blameworthy.

Answer: C

Explanation: **Disclosure requires necessity and proportionality** is the controlling principle. Snowden-type disclosure presents competing duties of confidentiality and democratic accountability; motive alone cannot replace necessity, minimisation, proportionality and prior-channel tests. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 44

A government engineer leaks only the documents necessary to prove concealed dam-safety risks after documented internal escalation fails. Which framework assesses whether the disclosure is ethically defensible despite a secrecy duty? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Nagel's taxonomy distinguishes resultant, circumstantial, constitutive and causal luck; Williams's treatment should not be presented as an identical four-part taxonomy.
- B. A moral-luck correction makes ex-ante diligence primary without making outcomes irrelevant: outcomes remain evidence and feedback, while negligence, bad faith and foreseeable omissions remain blameworthy.
- C. Ethical triage should combine evidence-based welfare maximisation with equal worth, non-discrimination, vulnerability safeguards, published criteria and periodic review.
- D. Snowden-type disclosure presents competing duties of confidentiality and democratic accountability; motive alone cannot replace necessity, minimisation, proportionality and prior-channel tests.

Answer: D

Explanation: **Disclosure requires necessity and proportionality** is the controlling principle. Snowden-type disclosure presents competing duties of confidentiality and democratic accountability; motive alone cannot replace necessity, minimisation, proportionality and prior-channel tests. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 45

Two equally diligent officers face different outcomes, while only one happened to be posted during a catastrophe. Which framework separates luck in results from luck in circumstances? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Nagel's taxonomy distinguishes resultant, circumstantial, constitutive and causal luck; Williams's treatment should not be presented as an identical four-part taxonomy.
- B. Ethical triage should combine evidence-based welfare maximisation with equal worth, non-discrimination, vulnerability safeguards, published criteria and periodic review.
- C. Snowden-type disclosure presents competing duties of confidentiality and democratic accountability; motive alone cannot replace necessity, minimisation, proportionality and prior-channel tests.
- D. A moral-luck correction makes ex-ante diligence primary without making outcomes irrelevant: outcomes remain evidence and feedback, while negligence, bad faith and foreseeable omissions remain blameworthy.

Answer: A

Explanation: Moral luck has four analytically distinct forms is the controlling principle. Nagel's taxonomy distinguishes resultant, circumstantial, constitutive and causal luck; Williams's treatment should not be presented as an identical four-part taxonomy. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 46

A discussion distinguishes outcome, situation, temperament and causal history as sources of factors beyond control. Which attribution caution prevents assigning the same fourfold classification indiscriminately to both philosophers? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Snowden-type disclosure presents competing duties of confidentiality and democratic accountability; motive alone cannot replace necessity, minimisation, proportionality and prior-channel tests.
- B. Nagel's taxonomy distinguishes resultant, circumstantial, constitutive and causal luck; Williams's treatment should not be presented as an identical four-part taxonomy.
- C. A moral-luck correction makes ex-ante diligence primary without making outcomes irrelevant: outcomes remain evidence and feedback, while negligence, bad faith and foreseeable omissions remain blameworthy.
- D. Ethical triage should combine evidence-based welfare maximisation with equal worth, non-discrimination, vulnerability safeguards, published criteria and periodic review.

Answer: B

Explanation: Moral luck has four analytically distinct forms is the controlling principle. Nagel's taxonomy distinguishes resultant, circumstantial, constitutive and causal luck; Williams's treatment should not be presented as an identical four-part taxonomy. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 47

A public-sector bank officer follows recorded due diligence, but an unforeseeable market shock later defeats the project. Which principle resists automatic misconduct inference while preserving review of the decision process? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Ethical triage should combine evidence-based welfare maximisation with equal worth, non-discrimination, vulnerability safeguards, published criteria and periodic review.
- B. Snowden-type disclosure presents competing duties of confidentiality and democratic accountability; motive alone cannot replace necessity, minimisation, proportionality and prior-channel tests.
- C. A moral-luck correction makes ex-ante diligence primary without making outcomes irrelevant: outcomes remain evidence and feedback, while negligence, bad faith and foreseeable omissions remain blameworthy.
- D. Nagel's taxonomy distinguishes resultant, circumstantial, constitutive and causal luck; Williams's treatment should not be presented as an identical four-part taxonomy.

Answer: C

Explanation: **Ex-ante process corrects outcome bias without excusing negligence** is the controlling principle. A moral-luck correction makes ex-ante diligence primary without making outcomes irrelevant: outcomes remain evidence and feedback, while negligence, bad faith and foreseeable omissions remain blameworthy. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 48

A road project succeeds despite the engineer ignoring mandatory soil tests. Which proposition explains why a fortunate outcome cannot vindicate a negligent process? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Snowden-type disclosure presents competing duties of confidentiality and democratic accountability; motive alone cannot replace necessity, minimisation, proportionality and prior-channel tests.
- B. Nagel's taxonomy distinguishes resultant, circumstantial, constitutive and causal luck; Williams's treatment should not be presented as an identical four-part taxonomy.
- C. Ethical triage should combine evidence-based welfare maximisation with equal worth, non-discrimination, vulnerability safeguards, published criteria and periodic review.
- D. A moral-luck correction makes ex-ante diligence primary without making outcomes irrelevant: outcomes remain evidence and feedback, while negligence, bad faith and foreseeable omissions remain blameworthy.

Answer: D

Explanation: **Ex-ante process corrects outcome bias without excusing negligence** is the controlling principle. A moral-luck correction makes ex-ante diligence primary without making outcomes irrelevant: outcomes remain evidence and feedback, while negligence, bad faith and foreseeable omissions remain blameworthy. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

Solved PYQ 1 - 2018 - 20 marks

Question: Neutral rendering of GS-IV Q4: (a) Examine whether a public servant may undertake a good act when it is not expressly prohibited by laws or rules. (b) Two views hold respectively that means are most important and that the ends justify the means. Which view is more appropriate? Justify. Combined format: 10 + 10 marks; two separate 150-word answers.

Source / ownership: Verified against the local 2018 GS-IV scan and the 2018-2023 routing ledger. Both subparts are retained; the combined 20 marks must not be represented as one undifferentiated 150-word answer.

Model solution

(a) Absence of an express prohibition does not create unlimited discretion. A public servant may take a beneficial initiative only when it lies within delegated authority, violates neither an express nor an implied restriction, serves a public purpose and remains available to all similarly placed citizens. Reasons should be recorded and reviewable. Deontology supplies the duty and equality floor; consequentialism tests hidden costs and precedent; phronesis distinguishes purposive initiative from favouritism. Accepting equivalent proof from every disaster-affected pensioner can be justified; selectively waiving eligibility for a political contact cannot.

(b) Ethical means deserve presumptive priority because dishonest or coercive methods damage dignity, legitimacy, trust and the very quality of the achieved end. Deontology rejects using persons merely as instruments, while virtue ethics asks what corrupt methods habituate. Consequences still matter: among lawful, rights-respecting means, administration should choose the option producing the greatest public benefit. A narrowly tailored emergency departure may be justified by necessity and proportionality, but a desirable end cannot routinely legalise fabrication, discrimination or torture. Therefore, clean means form the ethical floor and consequence-sensitive optimisation operates within it.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Solved PYQ 2 - 2023 - 20 marks

Question: Neutral rendering of GS-IV Q4: (a) Discuss whether emotional intelligence is more important than cognitive intelligence for success in life. (b) Differentiate moral intuition from moral reasoning with suitable examples. Combined format: 10 + 10 marks; two separate 150-word answers.

Source / ownership: Verified against the local 2023 GS-IV scan and the 2018-2023 routing ledger. Part (b) is directly owned here; part (a) is a necessary cross-topic bridge to the Emotional Intelligence owner.

Model solution

(a) Emotional intelligence enables self-awareness, regulation, empathy, social understanding and relationship management. These capacities help an administrator handle conflict, motivate teams and recognise the human impact of technically correct decisions. Cognitive ability remains indispensable for legal analysis, evidence, forecasting and domain competence. EQ without knowledge can become well-intentioned incompetence; IQ without emotional maturity can become insensitive or uncooperative administration. Success therefore depends on complementary deployment: cognitive ability identifies feasible solutions, while emotional intelligence helps select, communicate and implement them responsibly.

(b) Moral intuition is a rapid, felt judgment arising before explicit deliberation; moral reasoning is a slower, articulated test using facts, duties, consequences and virtues. A procurement officer's unease about a compliant bid is intuition. Checking beneficial ownership, conflicts and public loss is reasoning. Intuition offers speed and early warning but may reflect bias. Reasoning is transparent and appeal-resistant but may rationalise a predetermined preference. The defensible sequence is intuition as signal, reason as audit, followed by a revisable decision.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Solved PYQ 3 - 2024 - 20 marks

Question: GS-IV Q4: (a) Examine, with suitable examples, the proposition that just and unjust are contextual and that changing contexts must remain under scrutiny to prevent miscarriage of justice. (b) Examine, with suitable illustrations, the claim that mindless attachment to form while ignoring substance causes injustice, and that a perceptive civil servant should avoid such literalness and carry out the true intent. Combined format: 10 + 10 marks; two separate 150-word answers.

Source / ownership: Wording and format verified against books\mains\05 UPSC 2024 Paper-IV_Final 1.pdf. Context sensitivity must not be presented as unrestricted ethical relativism, and purposive administration must remain lawful.

Model solution

(a) Context changes facts, burdens and the foreseeable impact of a rule; it need not change the underlying values. Movement restrictions may protect life during a lethal outbreak but become disproportionate after the emergency. An automated benefit rule once considered neutral must be revised when evidence shows systematic exclusion of persons with disabilities. Phronesis connects stable commitments to dignity, equality and liberty with contemporary knowledge. Continuous scrutiny therefore prevents yesterday's reasonable application from becoming today's miscarriage of justice. The limit is anti-relativism: political convenience cannot redefine cruelty, discrimination or corruption as just.

(b) Form protects predictability and equality, but literal compliance becomes unjust when it defeats the lawful purpose it was designed to serve. A pension officer may accept statutorily equivalent identity proof from a flood victim instead of insisting on a destroyed document. Yet 'substance' cannot authorise ultra-vires waivers, selective compassion or concealment of reasons. The perceptive civil servant identifies purpose, confirms authority, treats similar cases alike, records the departure and enables review. Thus substance corrects mechanical literalism; legality and procedural safeguards prevent purposivism from becoming arbitrary discretion.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Solved PYQ 4 - 2024 - 10 marks

Question: GS-IV Q3(c): Explain the present-day meaning of the quotation attributed in the paper to Immanuel Kant: in law a person is guilty upon violating another's rights, whereas in ethics guilt may arise even from thinking of doing so. Format: 10 marks; one 150-word answer.

Source / ownership: Verified against books\mains\05 UPSC 2024 Paper-IV_Final 1.pdf. This is Q3(c) alone, not the full 30-mark Q3. The wording is not traceable to a Kant-published work; the nearest identified source is Louis Infield's 1930 translation of student lecture notes.

Model solution

The quotation distinguishes law's minimum external standard from ethics' wider assessment of the agent's maxim and disposition. Law ordinarily requires an observable act, attempt or legally defined omission before coercive liability arises. Ethical criticism can begin earlier: a public servant who deliberately plans to deny benefits on caste grounds has already adopted a wrongful maxim even if supervision prevents its execution.

The point is not that every passing thought creates equal moral guilt. Kantian evaluation concerns a willed maxim or settled intention, not an involuntary mental event. Contemporary administration therefore needs both codes of conduct, which specify enforceable external behaviour, and codes of ethics, which cultivate integrity, impartiality and respect. Ethical self-scrutiny prevents wrongful intentions from becoming official action, while law preserves due process by not punishing mere unchosen thoughts.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Solved PYQ 5 - 2024 - 10 marks

Question: GS-IV Q1(a): Critically examine from the ethical point of view the proposition that Artificial Intelligence can serve as a dependable input for rational administrative decision-making. Format: 10 marks; one 150-word answer.

Source / ownership: Verified against books\mains\05 UPSC 2024 Paper-IV_Final 1.pdf. The official English paper prints 'dependable'; normalised spelling is used in the neutral rendering rather than falsely claiming a verbatim quotation.

Model solution

AI can improve administrative consistency, pattern detection, speed and evidence use, supporting consequentialist goals of better service delivery and risk reduction. It is not an ethically self-sufficient or invariably dependable source. Biased data may reproduce exclusion; opaque outputs obstruct reasons and appeal; automation can dilute accountability and treat citizens as data points rather than persons with dignity.

A deontological floor requires legality, equality, privacy, due process and human responsibility. Consequence analysis should test false positives, distributional harm and long-term trust, not efficiency alone. Virtue ethics adds phronesis: an experienced official must know when to rely on, question or override an output. Therefore AI should be an auditable input under human oversight, with explainability, bias testing, grievance redressal and a named accountable authority; final moral responsibility cannot be delegated to the model.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Solved PYQ 6 - 2018 - 20 marks

Question: Neutral rendering of GS-IV Q12: Edward Snowden disclosed classified government surveillance material, claiming a moral obligation to inform the public despite legal prohibition. Analyse the episode by weighing the competing values and examine whether the disclosure was ethically justified. Format: 20 marks; one 250-word answer.

Source / ownership: Verified against the local 2018 GS-IV scan and routing ledger. Legal labels in the stem, including any characterisation as treason, must be treated as question framing rather than asserted as an independently settled conclusion.

Model solution

The dilemma is not simply legality versus conscience. It involves duties of confidentiality, rule of law and protection of legitimate security operations, set against privacy, democratic oversight, truthfulness and the public's right to know of potentially unlawful surveillance.

Deontology initially reveals conflicting duties: keeping an entrusted secret and respecting citizens as rights-bearing ends. A rights argument is needed to explain why one duty may prevail. Consequentialism weighs democratic correction and reduced abuse against operational damage, exposure of innocent persons, precedent and loss of institutional trust. Virtue ethics asks whether courage was joined by prudence, temperance and responsibility rather than self-display.

Ethical defensibility depends on method. The discloser should normally document the wrong, use protected internal or legislative oversight channels where reasonably available, disclose only what is necessary, redact unrelated sensitive information and accept independent scrutiny. Public disclosure becomes stronger where the harm is grave, internal channels are ineffective or complicit, and narrower disclosure can realistically secure accountability.

Thus a moral motive is relevant but insufficient. The qualified test is necessity, proportionality, minimisation, channel exhaustion and accountability. A targeted disclosure satisfying these conditions can be morally defensible despite a legal breach; indiscriminate release cannot claim automatic justification from a good end.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Solved PYQ 7 - 2019 - 20 marks

Question: Neutral rendering of GS-IV Q8: Civil servants have sometimes been implicated or imprisoned for bona-fide mistakes, unsettling the moral fibre of the services. Explain how this trend affects civil-service functioning and suggest measures to protect honest officers. Format: 20 marks; one 250-word answer.

Source / ownership: Verified against the local 2019 GS-IV scan and routing ledger. This is a cross-application of moral luck and is primarily routed to the honest-officials and case-study owners.

Model solution

Automatic suspicion after every failed decision confuses bad outcome with bad process. Resultant moral luck explains why an officer may be blamed more severely than an equally diligent colleague merely because unforeseeable events produced a worse result.

Such outcome bias encourages defensive administration: delay, excessive referral, avoidance of innovation, refusal to exercise lawful discretion and preference for inaction over public-interest risk. It weakens morale, deters capable recruits and can itself reduce welfare. Yet blanket immunity would shelter negligence and corruption.

Protection should therefore be process-based. Preliminary scrutiny must distinguish a vigilance angle from a genuine commercial or administrative decision that went wrong. Review the information available at the time, delegated authority, conflict disclosures, consultation, recorded alternatives, due diligence and treatment of foreseeable risk. Use expert screening, reasoned and time-bound sanction decisions, protection from repeated inquiries on identical facts, legal support for bona-fide action and penalties for malicious complaints. Outcomes should remain evidence and feedback, especially where warnings were ignored.

The ethical standard is neither success nor failure alone. It is demonstrable good faith, competence and reasonable process ex ante, combined with accountability for negligence, corrupt motive or concealment.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Solved PYQ 8 - 2021 - 20 marks

Question: Neutral rendering of GS-IV Q10: As a hospital administrator during an infectious COVID-19 crisis, identify and justify the criteria for deploying clinical and non-clinical staff, and examine whether the justification would differ in a private hospital. Format: 20 marks; one 250-word answer.

Source / ownership: Verified against the local 2021 GS-IV scan and routing ledger. The official demand concerns allocation of scarce staff, not directly ventilator or patient allocation.

Model solution

The administrator owes duties to patients, employees, families and the continuity of essential services. Relevant criteria are clinical competence, urgency of tasks, infection exposure, comorbid vulnerability, prior training, availability of PPE, rotation and recovery time, voluntariness where meaningful, and the minimum staffing needed outside COVID care.

Consequentialism supports deploying scarce expertise where it saves the most lives and prevents system collapse. Deontology prohibits treating staff merely as expendable resources: adequate protection, truthful risk communication, non-discrimination and reasonable accommodation remain mandatory. Virtue ethics requires courage joined with prudence and compassion. The process should publish objective criteria, train redeployed personnel, separate tasks by competence, provide PPE and insurance, rotate high-exposure teams, enable confidential health declarations and create rapid review for disputed assignments. Senior leadership should share burdens rather than transfer all risk downward.

The ethical justification does not fundamentally change in a private hospital. Ownership may affect contracts, finances and referral networks, but dignity, worker safety, clinical need and professional duty remain the same. Profit or employment power cannot justify avoidable exposure. A private institution may coordinate with public authorities and recover legitimate costs, but the common ethical floor is transparent, proportionate and competence-based deployment.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Solved PYQ 9 - 2022 - 20 marks

Question: Neutral rendering of GS-IV Q1: (a) Critically evaluate the claim that lack of wisdom in administration may cause even small errors to produce a travesty of justice. (b) Explain why empathy and compassion are vital attributes for civil servants. Combined format: 10 + 10 marks; two separate 150-word answers.

Source / ownership: Verified against the local 2022 GS-IV scan and routing ledger. Part (a) supports phronesis and purposive judgment; part (b) is cross-linked to Emotional Intelligence.

Model solution

(a) Administrative wisdom resembles phronesis: the capacity to connect rules, evidence, purpose and the particular human situation. A small clerical discrepancy can become a travesty when an official mechanically denies a widow's pension despite lawful alternative verification. Wisdom identifies what is essential, anticipates disproportionate harm and records a legally defensible solution. It is not permission to ignore rules; unstructured discretion can itself cause injustice. Training, consultation, speaking orders, review and attention to constitutional values convert experience into accountable judgment.

(b) Empathy enables a civil servant to understand another person's perspective and barriers; compassion adds motivation to relieve avoidable suffering. They improve policy design, respectful communication and detection of hidden exclusion. A collector who understands why persons with disabilities cannot use a digital-only portal can arrange accessible alternatives. However, compassion without impartial criteria may become favouritism, while empathy without competence may not solve the problem. These attributes should therefore activate careful inquiry and humane implementation within law, equality and evidence.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Solved PYQ 10 - 2025 - 20 marks

Question: GS-IV Q7 case study: Vijay, Deputy Commissioner of a remote hilly district, is leading rescue and relief after a destructive cloudburst when his mother dies in Kerala and messages urge him to perform the last rites as conditions deteriorate. (a) Identify his options. (b) Identify the ethical dilemmas. (c) Critically evaluate each identified option. (d) Select the most appropriate option and justify it. Combined format: 20 marks; one 250-word answer covering all four demands.

Source / ownership: Wording and four explicit sub-demands verified against books\mains\UPSC Mains 2025 GS Paper 4.pdf. The answer must remain one integrated 250-word response, not four separate 250-word answers.

Model solution

Vijay's options are: remain throughout the emergency; leave immediately for the last rites; briefly leave after transferring command; or arrange remote participation and travel only after stabilisation. The dilemmas are public duty versus filial and cultural obligation, irreplaceable personal loss versus responsibility for thousands, and whether delegation is responsible leadership or abandonment.

Remaining provides continuity, reassures teams and protects rescue operations, but imposes severe personal cost and may deny a final family duty. Immediate departure respects grief and last rites but is unsafe if command systems are fragile. A brief departure is defensible only with a competent incident commander, written delegation, communication redundancy, clear resource authority and an agreed recall threshold. Remote participation is operationally safest but may inadequately meet personal and cultural needs.

Deontology emphasises both entrusted public duty and familial obligation. Consequentialism gives great weight to avoidable mass harm during the deteriorating crisis. Virtue ethics requires practical wisdom, humanity and responsible delegation, not performative self-sacrifice. Motive, intention and consequence must be separated: filial love is a good motive, but an unplanned departure may create a defective operational intention; the final disaster outcome may also involve moral luck.

The best course is to stabilise command immediately, transparently inform superiors, delegate in writing to the strongest available officer and assess whether a strictly time-bound visit is operationally safe. If not, he should remain and arrange remote rites, with institutional support for later travel. This preserves life-saving duty without denying his humanity.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

ORIGINAL MAINS PRACTICE WITH MODEL SOLUTIONS

Original Mains Practice 1 - 10 marks

Question: Distinguish motive, intention and consequence as separate objects of moral appraisal in public administration. Answer in about 150 words.

Model solution

Motive is the background reason moving an agent; intention is the result and means deliberately chosen; consequence is what actually follows. They may point in different ethical directions. A district officer may be moved by compassion, intend an unauthorised preference for her native village, and accidentally produce a beneficial outcome. The good motive does not cure the discriminatory intention, and the fortunate result does not retrospectively make the process fair.

Deontology examines the maxim, duty and chosen means. Consequentialism compares expected effects, while virtue ethics considers the character expressed by motive and judgment. Actual outcomes still matter, but moral-luck analysis asks how much was foreseeable or controllable.

A sound administrative evaluation therefore records the officer's purpose, chosen course, information available at the time, foreseeable risks and realised effects separately. This prevents benevolent rhetoric from excusing unlawful conduct and prevents hindsight from condemning a diligent decision solely because chance produced a bad result.

Why this earns marks: The response defines the issue, develops the relevant mechanism with India-centric evidence, tests a limitation, and gives a mark-scaled conclusion.

Original Mains Practice 2 - 10 marks

Question: Differentiate act utilitarianism from rule utilitarianism through public administration examples. Answer in about 150 words.

Model solution

Act utilitarianism evaluates each particular act by asking which available choice will produce the greatest expected net welfare. A disaster officer may open a locked public building without prior approval to shelter families because delay would cause serious harm.

Rule utilitarianism instead asks which generally accepted rule produces the best long-run consequences. Transparent competitive procurement may therefore be retained even where direct selection appears faster in one ordinary purchase, because the rule protects predictability, trust and non-arbitrariness across cases.

The two can converge, but they can diverge over exceptions. Act utility risks short-term calculation, favouritism disguised as welfare and erosion of precedent. Rule utility risks rule worship when an exceptional emergency defeats the rule's own purpose. Public administration should normally use welfare-promoting rules, while allowing narrowly authorised, recorded and reviewable exceptions where necessity and proportionality are demonstrable. Fundamental dignity and equality remain a deontological floor rather than variables in the utility total.

Why this earns marks: The response defines the issue, develops the relevant mechanism with India-centric evidence, tests a limitation, and gives a mark-scaled conclusion.

Original Mains Practice 3 - 15 marks

Question: A public servant may do good where no law or rule expressly prohibits the act, but a good end does not automatically justify irregular means. Examine. Answer in about 200 words.

Model solution

Administrative initiative is necessary because rules cannot anticipate every human need. Yet silence in a rulebook is not a free-standing source of power. A beneficial act is ethically defensible only when the official has delegated authority, no express or implied prohibition applies, public resources are properly used, similarly placed citizens receive equal treatment and reasons are recorded for review.

The three theories expose different risks. Deontology asks whether the means violate duty, dignity or due process. Consequentialism compares immediate benefit with hidden costs, precedent, administrative capacity and long-term trust. Virtue ethics asks whether a prudent and just officer would regard the initiative as faithful to public purpose rather than compassionate favouritism.

For example, accepting an equivalent identity document from every flood-affected pensioner may fulfil a scheme's lawful substance. Fabricating eligibility records to pay deserving persons uses a dishonest means that damages accountability and cannot become proper merely because the recipients are needy.

Clean means should therefore form the presumptive floor. In genuine emergencies, a limited procedural departure may be defended through necessity and proportionality, provided core rights are preserved, the departure is documented and normal oversight is restored promptly. The appropriate ideal is principled initiative: purposive, equal, lawful and consequence-aware.

Why this earns marks: The response defines the issue, develops the relevant mechanism with India-centric evidence, tests a limitation, and gives a mark-scaled conclusion.

Original Mains Practice 4 - 15 marks

Question: Context-sensitive justice is not ethical relativism. Discuss through phronesis and the form-versus-substance problem. Answer in about 200 words.

Model solution

Context-sensitive justice means that stable ethical commitments may require different applications when facts, knowledge, technology or the distribution of burdens change. It does not mean that every community or official may redefine justice at will. Dignity, equality, legality and non-arbitrariness remain controlling standards.

Aristotelian phronesis explains the bridge. General rules cannot contain every material feature of a case; practical wisdom perceives which features matter and applies the rule's ethical purpose responsibly. Emergency movement restrictions may protect life during a lethal outbreak yet become disproportionate after the danger passes. An automated welfare rule may require revision when evidence reveals exclusion of persons with disabilities.

The same reasoning addresses form and substance. Form supplies consistency, notice and review. Substance prevents literal compliance from defeating the lawful purpose, as when equivalent proof can replace a document destroyed in a flood. However, a civil servant cannot invoke 'true intent' to invent power, favour associates or bypass an implied prohibition.

A defensible contextual decision therefore identifies the stable value, demonstrates the changed facts, confirms legal authority, treats comparable persons alike, records reasons and permits appeal. Phronesis corrects mindless literalism; institutional safeguards prevent practical wisdom from becoming personal relativism.

Why this earns marks: The response defines the issue, develops the relevant mechanism with India-centric evidence, tests a limitation, and gives a mark-scaled conclusion.

Original Mains Practice 5 - 20 marks

Question: Design an ethical framework for allocating scarce life-saving resources by reconciling deontology, consequentialism and virtue ethics. Answer in about 250 words.

Model solution

Scarcity creates a genuine divergence among moral theories. Consequentialism supports using clinical evidence to maximise lives or life-years saved and to avoid wasting resources on interventions unlikely to work. A deontological approach insists that every person has equal worth: caste, wealth, political influence, disability stigma or perceived social usefulness cannot decide priority. Virtue ethics adds phronesis, compassion, justice and courage in confronting cases not resolved by a formula.

A defensible framework should begin with transparent eligibility based on clinical need and evidence of likely benefit. Among materially similar patients, use a neutral tie-breaker such as lottery rather than status. Protect vulnerable groups against indirect discrimination, but do not convert vulnerability into an unexplained override of medical feasibility. Separate bedside clinicians from final allocation where possible, publish criteria in accessible languages, document decisions and provide rapid review. Reassess the framework as resources, evidence and disease patterns change.

Alternative approaches reveal the need for synthesis. Pure first-come allocation may reward geographic and informational advantage. Pure survival maximisation may devalue persons with chronic disability. Unstructured compassion invites inconsistency and VIP pressure.

The recommended hybrid is consequence-sensitive but rights-constrained: evidence determines where treatment can help, equal dignity limits forbidden distinctions, and phronesis manages residual conflict under recorded criteria. Communication must explain that non-selection is not a judgment of lesser human value, and palliative or alternative care remains owed to every person. The framework should undergo periodic ethical audit.

Why this earns marks: The response defines the issue, develops the relevant mechanism with India-centric evidence, tests a limitation, and gives a mark-scaled conclusion.

Original Mains Practice 6 - 20 marks

Question: Moral luck complicates the evaluation of good-faith administrative decisions, but cannot become an excuse for negligence. Analyse. Answer in about 250 words.

Model solution

Moral luck describes the tension between the principle that responsibility should track control and the fact that ordinary judgment is strongly influenced by matters beyond control. Nagel distinguishes resultant luck in outcomes, circumstantial luck in the situations faced, constitutive luck in temperament and capacities, and causal luck in the antecedent chain shaping choice. Williams should not be credited with an identical fourfold taxonomy.

Administration most directly encounters resultant and circumstantial luck. Two officers may conduct equally diligent procurement, yet only one contractor fails because of an unforeseeable market shock. An officer posted during a cloudburst faces choices that a colleague in a peaceful district never confronts. Judging solely by outcome encourages defensive governance, delay and avoidance of legitimate risk.

The corrective is an ex-ante process test: Was the officer competent and authorised? Were conflicts disclosed, alternatives examined, expert advice sought, foreseeable risks mitigated and reasons recorded on the information then available? This reflects the ARC logic of separating bona-fide error or a commercial decision gone wrong from misconduct.

Outcomes nevertheless remain relevant. They may reveal ignored warnings, support learning or show that assumptions require revision. A successful project cannot excuse skipped safety tests, just as an unforeseeable failure does not prove corruption. Moral luck protects sound good-faith judgment from hindsight bias; it does not protect bad faith, recklessness, concealment or negligent disregard of foreseeable harm. Independent review should test these recorded claims.

Why this earns marks: The response defines the issue, develops the relevant mechanism with India-centric evidence, tests a limitation, and gives a mark-scaled conclusion.